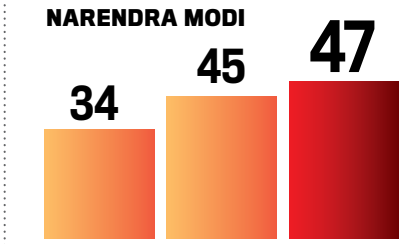
Congress Party (NCP) and the Congress, fights the Lok Sabha election as an alliance, the BJP tally could get severely dented. In 2019, the BJP-Sena combine won 41 of the 48 Lok Sabha seats in the state, with the BJP alone winning 23 of the 25 seats it contested. But both the overall and the individual party tally could well be in jeopardy this time—with the MOTN projections giving the NDA alliance just 14 seats, with the BJP winning 11 of them. Moreover, the outcome of the Mumbai and Thane municipal elections later this year will settle which faction of the Sena is the dominant one.

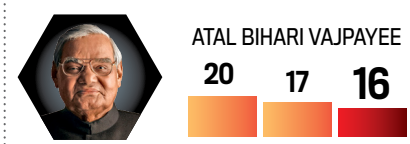
In Bihar too, the BJP may lose parliamentary seats in comparison to 2019 when the NDA included the Janata Dal (United) and the Lok Janshakti Party (LJP), and won 39 of the 40 seats. Partywise, the BJP won 17 seats, the JD(U) 16 and the LJP 6, with the Congress winning a mere one seat. This time, however, the NDA will not have the JD(U), as the BJP's main alliance partner and its leader, Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, broke away in August 2022 and joined hands with Tejashwi Yadav of the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD). The combined vote share of the JD(U) and the RJD could thwart the BJP's hopes of holding its own in Bihar, especially as even the LJP has deserted it. The MOTN projects only 14 seats for the BJP in Bihar.

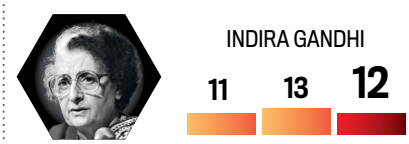
The other state in which the BJP had won big in 2019 was Karnataka, where it bagged 25 of 28 seats. The party is already on the back foot in the assembly election to be held this May, and if it loses to the Congress, it may find its tally dwindling in the Lok Sabha the next year. The MOTN projects the UPA's tally in Karnataka, Maharashtra and Bihar to tot up to 76 seats compared to the nine seats it won in 2019—a substantial gain of 67 seats.

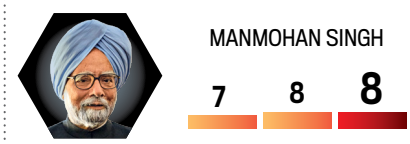
Q WHO HAS BEEN THE BEST PRIME MINISTER OF INDIA SO FAR?

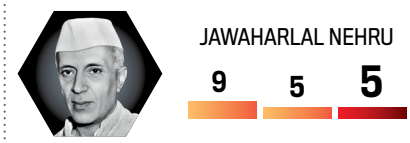












Rest others & DK/ CS

JAN. 2022 | AUG. 2022 | JAN. 2023

All figures in % and rounded off; DK/ CS: Don't know/ Can't say

The BJP is banking heavily on Modi's charisma and popularity to win the Lok Sabha seats in the states even if they lose the assembly polls in them, as in 2019. Though the Congress won the state elections in Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh, it was the BJP and its allies that swept 62 of the 65 seats in these states in the 2019 parliamentary polls. Another advantage Modi and the BJP have is that the Opposition remains fragmented, and so far, there is no clear pole that can be a viable alternative. Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra may have refurbished his image but the MOTN results reflect that a majority believes that the Congress has neither the leadership nor the organisational muscle to halt the BJP juggernaut. The MOTN survey also shows that the gap between Modi and Rahul Gandhi as preferred prime ministerial candidate remains wide at 39 per cent.

That said, the BJP still has other worries to sort out. For one, its successes may bring diminishing returns, a trend the MOTN survey

NARENDRA MODI VS INDIRA GANDHI

How the MOTN surveys reflected the popularity trends of two of India's prime ministers known for radical moves

